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THEATRE ARTS

DIRECTING

Blocking and Stage Pictures

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

How to arrange actors so the story is visible from every seat: levels, crosses, focus, and the difference between blocking that means something and blocking that merely moves.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- stage areas
- levels
- crosses and counter-crosses
- focus
- sightlines

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The stage is a map, and the map changes meaning

Downstage centre is the strongest position on a proscenium stage and should be spent, not used constantly. Upstage is weaker and older: an actor who retreats upstage loses the audience unless the lights and the blocking say otherwise. The diagonal from upstage right to downstage left reads as movement towards the audience; the opposite diagonal reads as withdrawal.

Before you block a scene, decide where the audience's eye should be at each moment. If two actors are talking and a third is listening, the third is the scene, and the picture should show it.

Levels are the cheapest drama you have

A character standing while another sits has power in the picture before anyone speaks. Use the furniture you have: a chair, a step, a table, the floor. Blocking that keeps everyone at the same height for twenty minutes is a flat photograph; blocking that changes height at the moment the balance of a scene changes is doing the play's work.

Do not invent levels the set cannot support. A director who blocks an actor onto a table in week two and discovers in week six that the table is a light prop has cost the production a week.

Crosses: give them a reason and a destination

Every cross should answer "why now, and why there". A cross on a line usually lands the line; a cross against the line usually shows the character resisting what is being said. Avoid the symmetrical cross that simply restores the picture after the last one; the audience sees the tidying and stops believing the scene.

Write the blocking down. Use a ground plan with a simple grid, mark entrances and furniture, and record each move in the script margin as a few words: "X to window on 'leave'". In week four, nobody will remember why the actor is at the window.

Composition, not decoration

A good stage picture has one centre of attention, a shape, and a relationship between the bodies in it. Triangles, diagonals and strong verticals read from the back of a hall; a straight line of actors all facing front reads as a choir. When you are stuck, change one thing: the distance between two people, or the direction one of them faces.

Check the picture from the worst seat in the house. If you cannot see the face of the actor who is speaking from the side seats, neither can the people who paid for them.

Blocking a crowd

Crowds are blocked in groups, not individuals. Divide the stage into areas, give each group an area and a leader, and give each group one action for the scene: the mourners enter and kneel, the servants clear the table, the guests drink and talk. Then give the principals their own paths through the groups. An audience reads a crowd as a mass with a few faces in it, and that is how it should be built.

Keep the crowd busy with business that belongs to the play: folding cloth, serving, carrying, waiting. Nothing destroys a serious scene faster than eight people standing still and watching two people talk. But keep the business quiet and repeatable, because a crowd that improvises will eventually improvise over the line that matters.

Rehearse the crowd separately. Twenty minutes with the ensemble on entrances, exits and the one picture you need will save an hour of the principal actors' time, and the ensemble will feel like a company rather than furniture.

The two-hour blocking rule

Never block more than two hours at a stretch, and never block a scene the actors have not read aloud. Blocking is the physical shape of an argument the actors have to understand first; a company that is walked around a stage before it understands the scene will perform the traffic and not the play.

Block in pencil. Every blocking plan changes in the first run, and a director who has inked the moves into a script will defend them past the point where they work. The blocking is a hypothesis about the scene, and the run is the test.

Exercises

1. Block a two-minute duologue three ways: both standing, one seated, both on the floor. Note what each version says before a word is spoken.
2. Take a photograph of each stage picture you build in a rehearsal and review the photographs at the end of the week.
3. Block a scene for a thrust stage and then for a proscenium, and list what had to change and why.

Where to read more

William Ball, A Sense of Direction (1984)

Harold Clurman, On Directing (1972)

Francis Reid, The Staging Handbook (1995)

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